

we hire someone externally for our training sessions. Our people have stepped up to be really involved and aware. And they train the rest of the organisation,” says P&G’s Srinivas. This includes running sensitisation for interviewers who may interview LGBTQ+ candidates as well. The consumer goods maker has made Ankur Bhagat, its Product Supply & Chief Supply Chain Officer, the Executive Sponsor for LGBTQ+ inclusion. Manufacturing giant Tata Steel has more than 100 transgender employees, mostly on its shop floors, with plans to increase the number by another 100 in FY24. “Whatever any employee is entitled to, that is what LGBTQ+ employees need to be entitled to, except for their medical treatment. So, gender transition and hormone therapy are over and above what other biologically so-called straight people require,” says Atrayee Sanyal, Vice President of HRM.

One stumbling block for the LGBTQ+ population, especially transgender people, can be around documentation as they may have dropped out of school/college or left jobs abruptly due to homophobia and transphobia. Axis Bank’s VP & Head (Diversity, Equity & Inclusion) Harish Iyer, who identifies as gender fluid and gay, speaks of an instance where a trans male candidate couldn’t get a relieving letter from his previous employer because he left in a hurry due to transphobia. “Normally, if you don’t get a relieving letter or have been absconding in your previous organisation, that’s a red flag.” But Iyer and his team managed to convince the previous employer to issue a relieving letter. Iyer, who failed Class 12 and at the MSc level, says: “My existence at Axis Bank itself speaks about



“We [the LGBTQ+ population] have people in middle management and lower management who identify as queer, but not in the top management. That’s the case with queer people worldwide”

HARISH IYER
VP & HEAD (DIVERSITY,
EQUITY & INCLUSION),
AXIS BANK



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ATRAYEE SANYAL
VICE PRESIDENT, HUMAN
RESOURCE MANAGEMENT,
TATA STEEL

our vision to look at talent from the lens of skills.” The lender runs ‘ARISE’, an initiative to hire candidates based on their skills and aptitude instead of their qualifications or the institute they attended, using little human interaction.

Tata Steel, which is usually particular about the colleges they hire from and candidates’ exam scores, makes relaxations on both counts for transgender candidates. “We can give a little bit of a relaxation at the entry level. But once they have entered, merit and merit alone will take them ahead,” says Sanyal.

Then, there is the issue of main-

taining confidentiality in cases where the employee is not out and proud. “When we were looking at creating gender-neutral policies around insurance and other benefits, we built it into the system that the employee information is entirely confidential,” says Manmeet Sandhu, Head of HR at fintech start-up PhonePe. The execution of LGBTQ+ policies make people uncomfortable about revealing their identity because one doesn’t know where the documents and forms may go, says P&G’s Bhagat. “At P&G India, if somebody wants to avail of an LGBTQ-friendly policy,